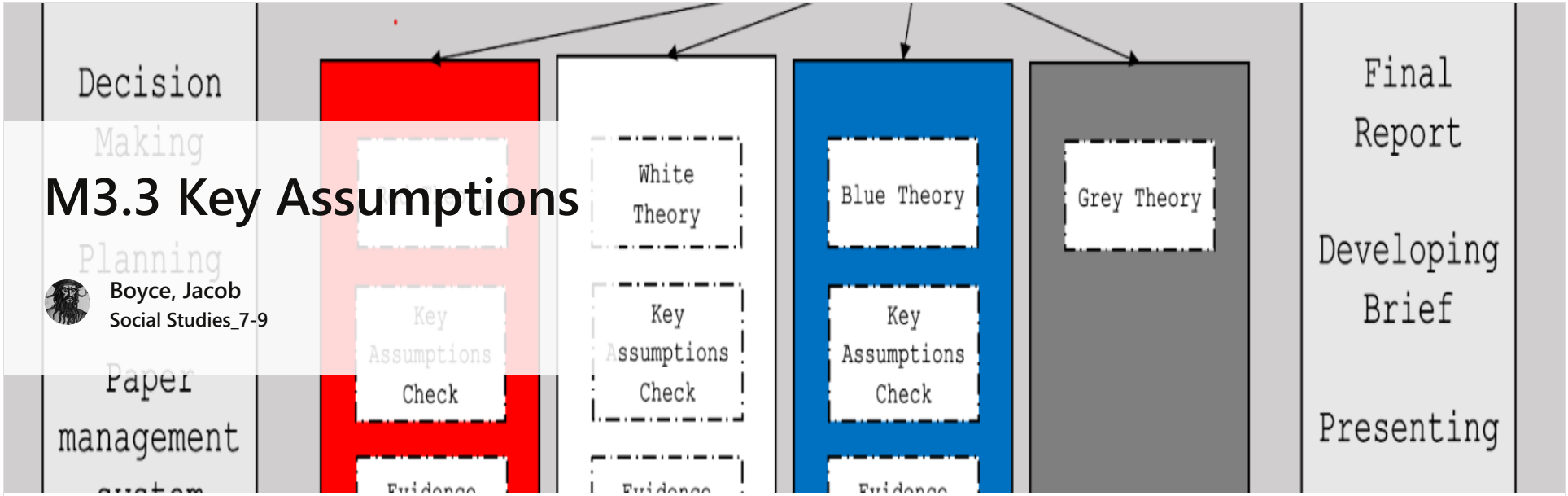


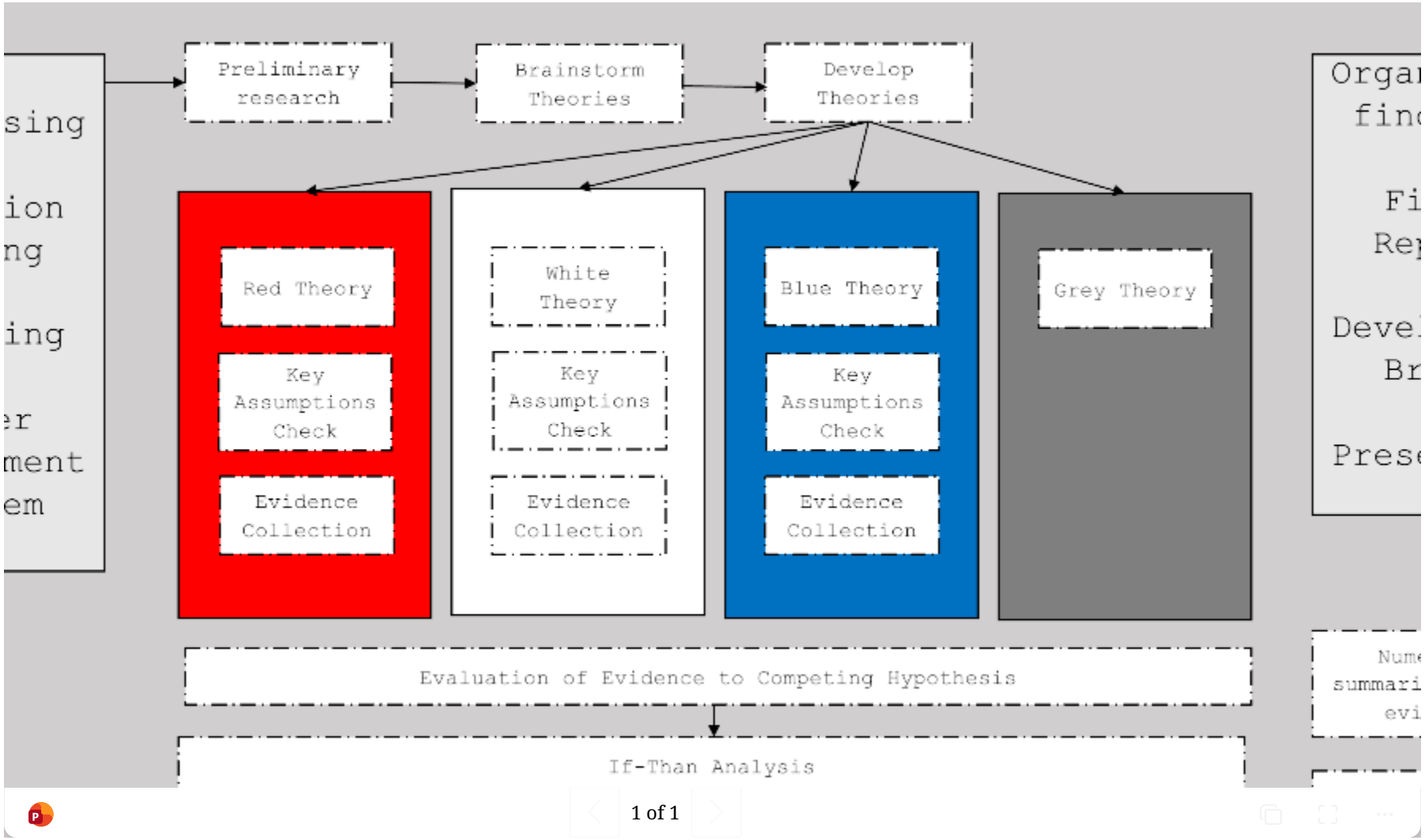
M3.3 Key Assumptions

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Social Studies_7-9

Key Assumptions Check

A key assumption check is a critical part of the analytical process, especially when analyzing conspiracy theories, as it helps ensure that judgments and conclusions are based on valid premises. The primary goal is to identify and evaluate the assumptions that form the foundation of an analysis, often those accepted without scrutiny. The importance of a key assumption check lies in its ability to:

1. Uncover hidden biases and faulty logic: By challenging assumptions, it prevents analysts from jumping to conclusions or making decisions based on incomplete or unexamined premises
2. Promote openness to new information: It encourages analysts to reconsider existing assumptions when new evidence arises, ensuring that conclusions remain flexible and adaptable
3. Enhance critical thinking: It forces the analyst to critically assess the validity of each assumption and its relevance, especially in light of evolving situations
4. Prevent overlooking important factors: Through systematic questioning, it can expose overlooked relationships and variables that may be key to understanding a situation


Preliminary research
Brainstorm Theories
Develop Theories
Red Theory
Key Assumptions Check
Evidence Collection
White Theory
Key Assumptions Check
Evidence Collection
Blue Theory
Key Assumptions Check
Evidence Collection
Grey Theory
Evaluation of Evidence to Competing Hypothesis
If-Than Analysis
1 of 1



9 Questions down the rabbit hole with Key Assumptions

Starting with Fiction

1. **What are some examples of key assumptions that characters in a movie or book believed to be true? How did these assumptions impact their decisions and the story's outcome?**
2. **Can you think of a time in a story where a character had to change their views because their assumptions were proven wrong? What led to that change?**

Bridging to Personal and Real-World Contexts

1. **What are some common sayings or beliefs that people often accept without question in our community or society? Why do you think they are rarely challenged?**
2. **How does someone's background, such as where they grow up or their family's beliefs, influence the assumptions they make about others. Can you give an example?**

Delving into Controversial Topics

1. **Why might it be difficult to question or challenge assumptions that are tied to our identity, like your religion or the political beliefs of your family? How we answer questions like "why are poor people poor," and "why is terrorism more prevalent in Arab nations" go a long way to understanding key assumptions**
2. **What are some potential consequences of never questioning assumptions about things like religion, politics, or social class?**
3. **In what ways can questioning our assumptions lead to better understanding and relationships between people of different backgrounds? Can it sometimes cause conflict?**

Encouraging Personal Reflection and Growth

1. **Think about a belief or assumption you have had about someone or something that changed when you received new information. What was the belief, and what changed your mind?**
2. **If you were to question one assumption that you have about your own community, religion, or family's political beliefs, what would it be and why? How would you go about finding more information?**

The Conspiracy Theory Industrial Complex: Monetization and Markets.

The Emergence of Conspiracy Theories as Business

- **Historical Context**: Initially, conspiracy theories were limited to niche groups and not widely accepted or known.
- **Role of the Internet**: The digital age has propelled these theories into the mainstream, providing a platform for rapid dissemination and community building.
- **Case Study: Alex Jones**: Founder of InfoWars, Jones transformed his media platform into a hub for conspiracy theories, significantly influencing their commercialization.

Revenue Streams from Conspiracy Theories

- **Direct Sales**: InfoWars, for example, sells a range of products from survival gear to health supplements, directly linking merchandise to the theories broadcasted.
  - **Example**: During the COVID-19 pandemic, Jones advertised products like dietary supplements, which he misleadingly claimed could ward off the virus.
- **Advertising Revenue**: Websites hosting conspiracy content often see high traffic volumes, which translate to substantial ad revenue.
- **Subscription Models**: Some creators offer additional content for a fee, including exclusive videos and articles, fostering a gated community feeling.

Economic Markets and Consumer Behavior

- **Target Market Analysis**: Typically, consumers of conspiracy theory content are individuals who distrust mainstream media and are looking for alternative explanations.
- **Psychological Drivers**: Factors such as fear and the allure of being privy to 'forbidden knowledge' motivate consumption.
  - **Example**: Merchandise related to QAnon exploits the desire for belonging to a cause, evidenced by apparel and accessories emblazoned with cryptic symbols.

Impact of Conspiracy Theories on Traditional Markets

- **Mainstream Business Impact**: Some businesses find themselves inadvertently caught in conspiracy theories, which can lead to boycotts or unwanted attention.
  - **Example**: The Pizzagate conspiracy led to a significant, direct impact on Comet Ping Pong, a pizzeria in Washington, D.C., including a violent incident involving a gunman.
- **Stock Market and Commodity Prices**: At times, false information can lead to temporary stock volatility, affecting investments and perceptions.

Legal and Ethical Considerations

- **Legal Challenges**: Figures like Alex Jones have faced numerous legal challenges due to the content they promote, balancing on the edge of free speech and harmful misinformation.
- **Ethical Dilemmas**: Platforms that host and profit from conspiracy content wrestle with the ethical implications of their revenue strategies, especially when such content causes real-world harm.

Looking Forward

- **Future Trends**: We are likely to see an evolution in how conspiracy theories are monetized, with new technologies and platforms playing pivotal roles.
- **Navigational Strategies**: Both consumers and businesses must develop strategies to deal with misinformation—emphasizing critical thinking and verification.

- **Score: 0.3** (Weak, as it focuses on isolated incidents)

5. **Assumption: The Steelers' Super Bowl victories were influenced by illegal tactics or cheating.**

- **Why is this assumption correct?** Some argue that the team's success is the result of rule-bending, such as illegal hits, strategic fouls, or game manipulation.
- **How confident am I that this assumption is valid?** Very low confidence. There is no verified evidence to suggest that any Super Bowl victories were marred by cheating.
- **What could invalidate this assumption?** Detailed reviews of game footage and fair investigations showing that no illegal tactics were used would invalidate this assumption.
- **Could this assumption have been true in the past but false now?** Unlikely. Super Bowl victories are rigorously analyzed and reviewed, and no substantial evidence of cheating has been found.
- **How would this assumption's invalidation affect the analysis?** Disproving this assumption would significantly weaken the overall hypothesis that the Steelers are cheaters.
- **Score: 0.1** (Very weak, as there is no credible evidence supporting this claim)

Summary of Scores:

- **Assumption 1:** 0.4
- **Assumption 2:** 0.3
- **Assumption 3:** 0.2
- **Assumption 4:** 0.3

- **Assumption 5:** 0.1

Total Score: **1.3/5** (Weak overall support for the hypothesis, with multiple assumptions being poorly supported or based on subjective claims)